



P05 · 30 CARDS · AGES 3-10

The 30-Day Screen-Free Family Challenge

*Thirty daily challenge cards. One small activity per day,
most under twenty minutes, most using stuff you already
own. Plus a parent-prep guide and a no-shame tracker.*

Soothemade Notes

A SMALL APOTHECARY OF PRINTABLES · MADE SLOWLY

A note before you start

This isn't a "screens are evil" detox. Screens aren't evil. They're a tool that works really well some of the time and really poorly other times, and in our house at least, they'd quietly become the default for all the other times.

A 30-day challenge isn't about hating screens. It's about remembering what the other tools are.

You don't have to do this for 30 consecutive days. You can do 4 days a week. You can do it as a 7-day reset before vacation. You can ignore half the cards. You can do them out of order.

You can use one screen at a time as a fallback (e.g., a movie night, a video call with grandma) and still get most of the benefit. The goal isn't purity. The goal is breaking the default.

The cards are designed to:

- Take 15–45 minutes each (no all-day craft project that ends in tears)
- Use stuff you almost certainly already own
- Work indoors AND outdoors
- Be doable with one parent + a few kids
- Not require Pinterest-perfect execution

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This is a planning tool, not parenting advice. You know your kids better than any deck of cards. Adapt freely.

How to use this deck

1. **Print on cardstock** (recommended) or regular paper. Cut along the lines. Each card is 4.25"×5.5" (quarter of US Letter).
2. **Store in a basket or jar** in the kitchen or living room.
3. **Pull one in the morning** with the kids. Read it together. (Or pull 3 and let them pick.)
4. **Use the tracker** at the back. Color in the box for each day you do a card. No perfection, half-finished cards count.
5. **Skip cards that don't fit your kid.** Some are better for 3-year-olds, some for 8-year-olds. Use your judgment.
6. **You can repeat cards.** "Build a fort" is a Tuesday card. It's also a fine Friday card.

PARENT-PREP GUIDE (read once before starting)

What to expect on day 1

Your kids will ask for a screen. Probably more than once. Possibly with crying.

This is normal. It's also temporary. Most families report the asking drops off by day 3, and is gone by day 5-7.

A few things that help:

- **Name the deal in advance.** "We're trying a thing where we use these cards instead of [show / iPad / etc]. It might feel weird at first."
- **Don't punish the asking.** "I know it's hard, you're allowed to be mad. We're still doing the card."
- **Have one card ready before they get bored.** Boredom is fine, but the first 5 minutes of boredom are loud.

What to do when it gets hard

It will. Usually around day 6-10. Cards that worked won't work anymore. Kids get whiny. You get tired.

Options:

- **Take a break day.** Doing 5 of 7 days a week is still a win.
- **Lower the bar.** A 5-minute card still counts.
- **Switch up the cards.** Pull a stack of outdoor-only or quiet-only cards if you need a specific mood.
- **Co-opt a kid as the activity-picker.** Give them the pile, let them choose. Buy-in.

What success looks like

It's not "perfect 30/30 days." It's:

- Less default-screen behavior, even if not zero
- The kids start suggesting card-style activities on their own
- You feel less like a "no" machine
- The 4pm hour (the hardest one) has 3–4 things you can pull

The night-before-each-day adult prep

Two minutes the night before. Look at the next card. Note:

- Is the weather an issue?
- Do I have the materials?
- Is anyone going to need a "starter"?

That's it. Don't overplan.

The "screen exception" rule

Decide your exceptions in advance (so they don't feel like failures):

- Sick days
- Travel days (long car rides, flights, survival mode)
- Specific shared family activities (movie night)
- One parent's emergency work call

Write them on the inside of the card box / basket. When in doubt, use the exception.

THE 30 CARDS

Each card is one page. Format: title, age range, time, materials, instructions, optional extension.



Card 1, Fort Build

Best for: ages 3–10 **Time:** 30–45 min build + as long as they're in it **Materials:** blankets, pillows, chairs, clothespins (optional)

Build a fort together. Sheets over chairs, pillows for walls, a flashlight inside. They direct, you assist. Put nothing on the floor that you'll trip on at 2am.

Extension: Eat lunch in the fort. Read a book in there. Sleep in there if you're feeling unhinged.



Card 2, Cardboard City

Best for: ages 4–10 **Time:** 60 min (across the day if needed) **Materials:** any cardboard boxes, scissors (parent-supervised), markers, tape

Cut cardboard into buildings. Mark them as house / store / bank / firehouse. Draw windows. Set them up on the floor. Use toys as the residents. Stay there as long as it works.

Extension: Add roads with masking tape on the floor.



Card 3, Kitchen Bakery

Best for: ages 3–10 **Time:** 45 min **Materials:** flour, water, salt (for salt dough), or any cookie/biscuit recipe

Make something that ends up edible (real recipe) or play-doh-ish (salt dough: 2 cups flour, 1 cup salt, 1 cup water. bake at 200°F for 2 hours OR just air-dry). Let the kid measure. Let them dump too much flour somewhere. Wipe later.

Extension: Run a “bakery” where you order from their menu.



Card 4, Inside Treasure Hunt

Best for: ages 3–10 **Time:** 30 min (10 to set up, 20 to play) **Materials:** paper for clues, 1 small reward

Hide a “treasure” (a small toy, a snack, a coin). Write 5–6 clue cards that lead from one to the next, each card directing them to the next location. Kids 3–5 can do picture clues. Kids 7+ can do riddles.

Extension: Let the kid hide a treasure for YOU.



Card 5, Walking Nature Inventory

Best for: ages 3–10 **Time:** 20–40 min **Materials:** a paper bag or pocket

Go on a walk. Pick up: 1 rock, 1 leaf, 1 stick, 1 thing-shaped-like-a-heart, 1 thing-that-is-yellow. Talk about each thing on the way home. Display the collection on a windowsill for a day, then return it to the world.

Extension: Make a collage when you get home.



Card 6, Family Mailbox

Best for: ages 5–10 **Time:** 20 min/day for several days **Materials:** paper, envelopes, a basket or box

Set up a “family mailbox.” Each family member gets one. For the next 5–7 days, leave each other letters, drawings, questions, jokes, kind things. Check daily. Reply.

Extension: Add stamps (stickers).



Card 7, Bath Sensory Day

Best for: ages 2–6 **Time:** 30 min **Materials:** food coloring (optional), measuring cups, small toys

Run a midday bath. Add 1–2 drops of food coloring. Toss in measuring cups, small bowls, plastic dinosaurs. Let them pour and dump for as long as they want.

Extension: Add bubbles, or a “bath painting” with shaving cream on the tile.



Card 8, Pillow Floor Avalanche

Best for: ages 3–10 **Time:** 30 min **Materials:** every pillow in the house

Move every pillow and cushion into one room. Pile them. Jump in them. Hide in them. Build a slide. Use your judgment about furniture and necks.

Extension: Tape “lava” zones on the floor (the floor is lava classic).



Card 9, Big Drawing on Big Paper

Best for: ages 2–10 **Time:** 30–60 min **Materials:** roll of brown craft paper or taped-together computer paper, markers/crayons

Tape a giant sheet to the table or floor. Everyone gets a marker. Draw together. No theme required. Or draw a city, or a forest, or a portrait of each family member.

Extension: Cut it up and make a card or collage.



Card 10, Library Trip

Best for: ages 0–10 **Time:** 60 min (with travel) **Materials:** library card

Go to the library. Each kid picks 3–5 books. Read one there. Take the rest home.

Extension: Check what events the library has this week. Many have free storytime / puppet shows / craft hours.



Card 11, Lego Challenge

Best for: ages 4–10 **Time:** 30–60 min **Materials:** any Legos or building blocks you own

Set a single challenge. “Build something that can hold an egg.” “Build a tower taller than the chair.” “Build a vehicle that has wheels and can carry a stuffed animal.” Test the result.

Extension: Make it a parent-vs-kid build-off.



Card 12, Family Karaoke

Best for: any age **Time:** 30 min **Materials:** a phone (one screen exception OK), or just acapella, hairbrush microphones

Pick one song. Everyone takes a turn singing. Use hairbrushes. Tip: rotate "performer" / "audience" so no one's just standing around.

Extension: Make a playlist of "the family hits."



Card 13, Dance Party

Best for: any age **Time:** 15–30 min **Materials:** music (radio, alexa, anything non-screen)

Turn on music. Dance like idiots. Stop on freeze. Have the kid call freeze. Have the dog be the judge.

Extension: Add costumes (a sheet as a cape, etc).



Card 14, Stuffed Animal Hospital

Best for: ages 3–7 **Time:** 30 min **Materials:** stuffed animals, bandages (or paper towels), markers

Set up a "hospital" in the living room. Kid is the doctor. Stuffed animals come in injured. Treat them. Discharge them. Repeat.

Extension: Make a clipboard with patient charts.



Card 15, Cook Dinner Together

Best for: ages 4–10 **Time:** 45–60 min **Materials:** any dinner you were going to make anyway

Let them help. Crack eggs. Stir. Tear lettuce. Wash veggies. Salt the pasta water. Yes, they'll make a mess. Yes, dinner will take longer. Yes, it's worth it.

Extension: Let them pick what's for dinner tomorrow.



Card 16, Read-Aloud Marathon

Best for: any age (especially 2–8) **Time:** 30–90 min **Materials:** books

Pick 5 picture books or one chapter book chapter. Build a reading nest with pillows. Read until you're done or until they're done. Don't rush.

Extension: Drink something warm while reading. Hot chocolate or tea.



Card 17, Outdoor Obstacle Course

Best for: ages 3–10 **Time:** 30 min **Materials:** outside stuff (sticks, jump rope, chairs, cones, sidewalk chalk)

Set up 5–8 stations: jump over the rope, hop on one foot to the tree, crawl under the chair, etc. Time them with a real clock or stopwatch. Race them. Rebuild.

Extension: Let them design the course for you.



Card 18, Tape Road on the Floor

Best for: ages 2–6 **Time:** 30–60 min **Materials:** masking tape (won't damage floors), toy cars

Make roads on the floor with masking tape. Add intersections, parking lots, a gas station. Drive cars. Let them lead.

Extension: Add cardboard "buildings" from Card 2.



Card 19, Pretend Restaurant

Best for: ages 3–7 **Time:** 45 min **Materials:** paper for menu, toy food / real snacks, kid table

Open a restaurant in the kitchen. They write the menu. You order. They cook (real snacks or pretend). They serve. You tip with stickers.

Extension: Switch roles.



Card 20, Window Watercolor (or Markers)

Best for: ages 3–8 **Time:** 30 min **Materials:** dry-erase markers OR watercolor paint + soap (it washes off windows)

Draw on a window. Yes really. They love this. Wash with soapy water when done.

Extension: Make stained-glass: trace with markers, then “fill in” with crayon shaving + iron between wax paper.



Card 21, Recipe Inventor

Best for: ages 5–10 **Time:** 30 min **Materials:** snack ingredients

Let the kid invent a snack. Pretzels + cream cheese + raisins + a chocolate chip on top? Sure. Banana with peanut butter and crushed cereal? Sure. They make it. They eat it. (Or learn that some inventions don’t work.)

Extension: Vote on best invention of the week.



Card 22, Mystery Bag Touch Game

Best for: ages 3–8 **Time:** 20 min **Materials:** a pillowcase or bag, 5 household items

Put 5 random objects in a pillowcase: a spoon, a sock, a piece of fruit, a hairbrush, a toy. Kid reaches in and guesses each by touch. Switch.

Extension: Use harder objects. Make it a competition.



Card 23, Garden / Pot Planting

Best for: ages 3–10 **Time:** 30–45 min **Materials:** soil, seeds, a pot or planter

Plant something simple, herbs (basil), salad greens (lettuce), or fast-growers (radishes). Water daily. Check daily. Eat eventually.

Extension: Track growth on a kid-made chart.



Card 24, Family Letter to the Future

Best for: ages 5–10 **Time:** 30 min **Materials:** paper, an envelope, a calendar

Write a letter to the family one year from today. What's everyone like now? What are you hoping for? Seal it. Put it somewhere. Open it next year.

Extension: Hide it in a book on the shelf so it's a surprise next year.



Card 25, Quiet Reading Hour

Best for: ages 4+ **Time:** 60 min **Materials:** books

Everyone in the family takes 60 minutes of quiet reading time. Same room, different books. Kid books, adult books, comic books. The point is shared quiet.

Extension: End with everyone sharing one thing from their book.



Card 26, Backyard Camping

Best for: ages 4–10 **Time:** 1–2 hrs (or overnight if you're brave) **Materials:** sleeping bags, blanket, tent (optional)

Set up "camp" in the backyard. Spread blankets. Eat dinner outside. Tell stories. Stay until bedtime, OR sleep out there if the weather and bugs cooperate.

Extension: Make a no-fire "fire" with a flashlight and red paper.



Card 27, DIY Mailbag Delivery

Best for: ages 4–8 **Time:** 30 min **Materials:** envelopes, drawings, a basket / bag

Make 5 "deliveries" around the house, to family members, to pets, to stuffed animals. Each delivery is a drawing or note. Kid is the mail carrier. Wear an old satchel.

Extension: "Deliver" a real card to a neighbor (with permission).



Card 28, Storytelling Round

Best for: ages 4–10 **Time:** 20 min **Materials:** none

Sit together. One person starts a story with one sentence. The next person adds a sentence. Keep going. The story gets weirder. Don't try to control where it goes.

Extension: Write down the story. Illustrate it.



Card 29, Big Cleaning Job (as a “mission”)

Best for: ages 4–10 **Time:** 45 min **Materials:** rags, bucket, soap

Pick ONE area that needs cleaning. Make it a mission. “We’re cleaning the toy shelf, everything goes off, we sort it, we put back the keepers.” Reward at the end (a treat, a high-five, a new book).

Extension: “Donate” pile gets bagged and actually donated this week.



Card 30, The “Best Of” Day

Best for: any **Time:** flexible **Materials:** the cards you’ve already done

It’s day 30. Look back at the tracker. Pick the kid’s favorite card from the month. Do it again. End with a family ice cream or a small celebration.

Extension: Frame the tracker chart for the kid’s room. They did this.

TRACKER PAGE

Print this once. Color in a box each day you do a card. No perfect. Half-finished counts.

DAY: 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐

DAY: 11 12 13 14 15 16 17 18 19 20

☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐

DAY: 21 22 23 24 25 26 27 28 29 30

☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐

THE FAVORITE CARD: _____

ONE THING THIS CHALLENGE TAUGHT US: _____

ONE THING WE'LL KEEP DOING AFTER: _____

A note for after

When the 30 days end, two things usually happen:

1. **Your kids will ask for the cards again.** Some of the activities will become regular things. The fort. The window markers. The dinner-cook-together.
2. **You'll lose some of the discipline.** Screens will creep back. That's fine. The point wasn't permanent purity. The point was breaking the default, and giving everyone the muscle memory that there are other things.

You can re-run the challenge any time. Different season, different rotation. Or just keep the basket of cards in the kitchen as the fallback when you're about to default-screen and you stop yourself.

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This is a parenting tool, not advice for every family. Adapt freely. If your family has specific accessibility needs that change which cards are doable, modify away, that's the point.



Soothemade *Notes*

*Made for the version of you no one tells you about, the
one at four in the morning, the one in the parking lot, the
one who doesn't recognize her own week.*

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